

PRESENT DAY



LAI THE **FOUNDATIONS**
FOR THE THEORY OF
PLATE
TECTONICS

CALCULATED
THAT **ALL** 
CONTINENTS
WERE JOINED AS A
SINGLE LAND MASS
C.300
MILLION
YEARS AGO

and pointed out that he could not explain how or why the continents had moved. To find more evidence, Wegener made three more expeditions to Greenland, but on the last, in 1930, he died from overexertion.

In the 1950s and 1960s, new evidence emerged that supported Wegener's theory. It was discovered that the Earth's crust is made up of gigantic tectonic plates, which move as convection currents bring molten lava up to the surface. Decades after Wegener's time, the jigsaw puzzle was solved.

MARIE THARP

Marie Tharp was a geologist and cartographer who charted the ocean floor. Her maps identified the mid-Atlantic rift—powerful evidence for the theory of continental drift.



During World War II, American women were encouraged to enroll in "masculine" disciplines, and Tharp (1920–2006) graduated in petroleum geology. She also learned technical drawing and got a job producing hand-drawn maps of the ocean depths from raw data. In 1953, she made a remarkable discovery—that there is a 9,941-mile (16,000-km) ridge in the middle of the Atlantic, with a deep rift at its center. Although she never argued for the theory of continental drift, her discovery supported it.